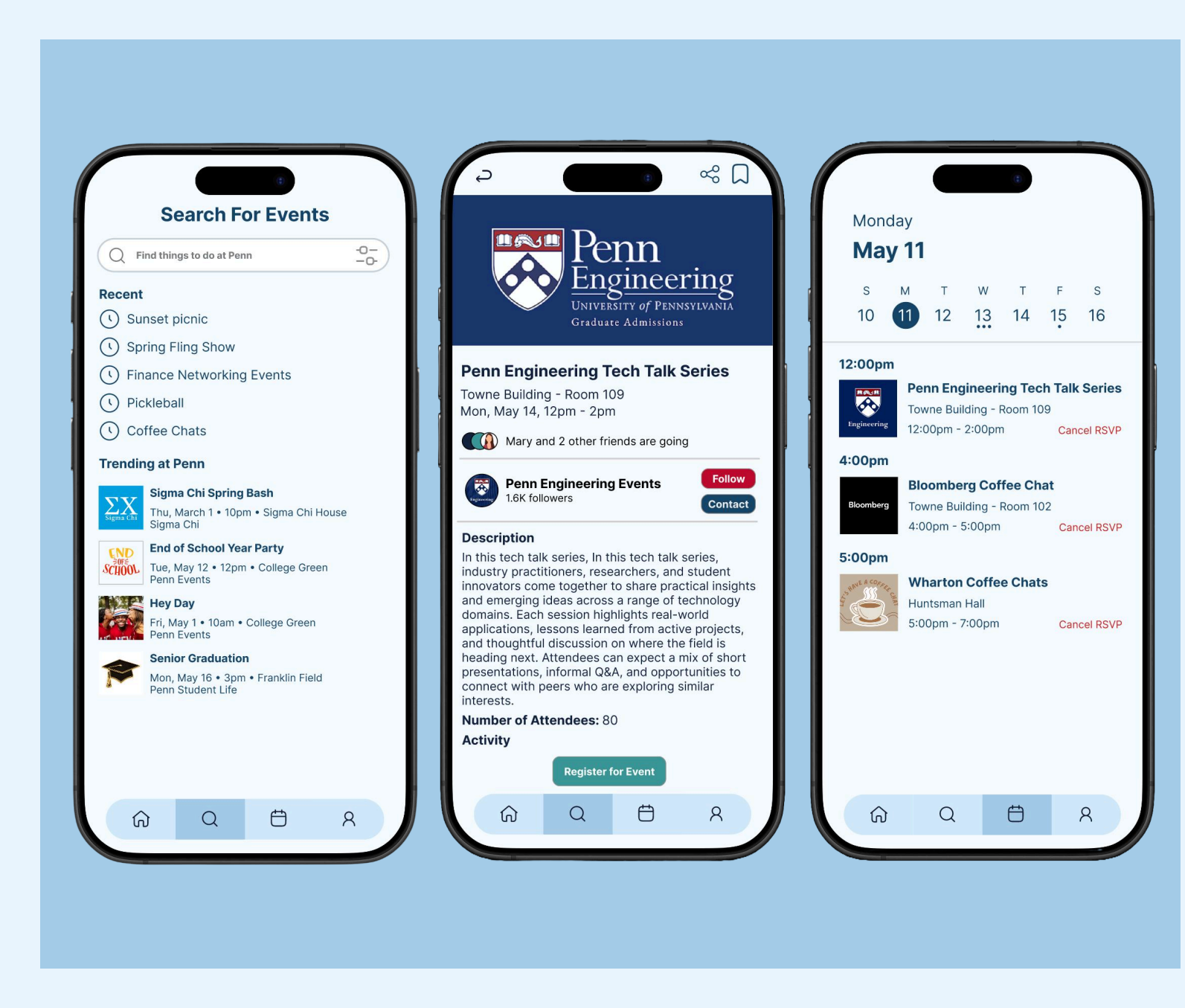
PennEvents

by: Rena Li

This project explores how a centralized mobile platform can improve campus event discovery for Penn students through personalized recommendations, social interaction, and streamlined event management. The app combines features such as a personalized FYP, Reels-style event discovery, messaging, calendar integration, and event hosting tools into one cohesive experience.

While the platform includes event hosting functionality, the design primarily focuses on the student experience of discovering, registering for, and managing events.

The goal of the project was to reduce the friction students face when trying to discover and keep track of campus events across multiple disconnected platforms.


Search For Events
Find things to do at Penn
Recent
Sunset picnic
Spring Fling Show
Finance Networking Events
Pickleball
Coffee Chats
Trending at Penn
Sigma Chi Spring Bash
End of School Year Party
Hey Day
Senior Graduation
Penn Engineering
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
Towne Building - Room 109
Mon, May 14, 12pm - 2pm
Mary and 2 other friends are going
Penn Engineering Events
Follow
Contact
Description
Number of Attendees: 80
Activity
Register for Event
Monday
May 11
S M T W T F S
10 11 12 13 14 15 16
12:00pm
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
Towne Building - Room 109
12:00pm - 2:00pm
Cancel RSVP
4:00pm
Bloomberg Coffee Chat
Towne Building - Room 102
4:00pm - 5:00pm
Cancel RSVP
5:00pm
Wharton Coffee Chats
Huntsman Hall
5:00pm - 7:00pm
Cancel RSVP

Problem

Currently, there is no centralized platform where Penn students can easily discover and manage campus events. Students often rely on scattered and inconsistent sources to learn about opportunities happening around campus.

Current Pain Points

- Searching through long email chains
- Relying on word of mouth
- Browsing multiple Instagram accounts
- Missing events due to lack of visibility
- Manually adding events to Google Calendar
- Limited awareness of which events friends are attending

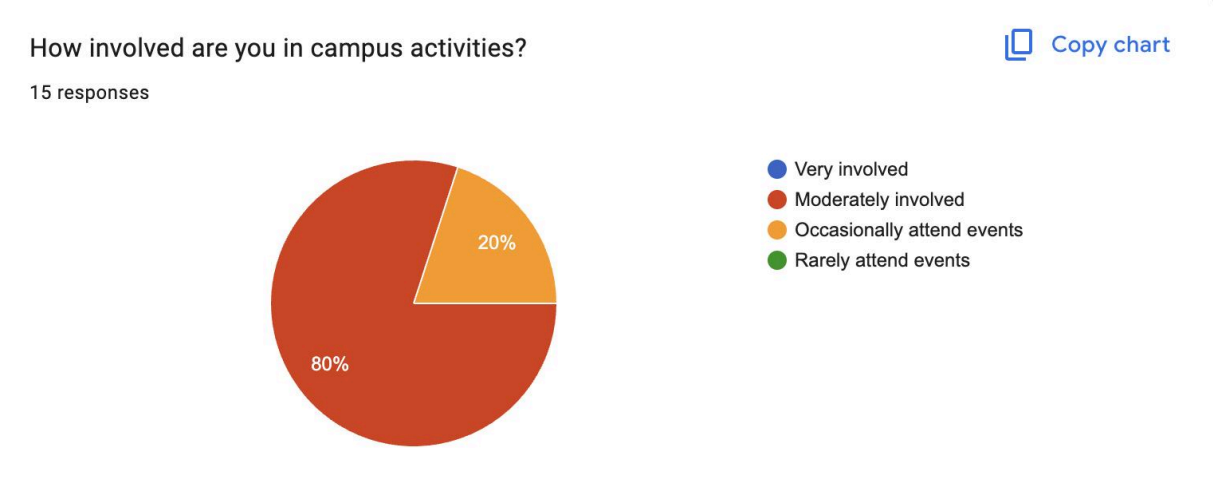
This fragmented process makes event discovery overwhelming and unreliable, causing students to miss social, academic, and professional opportunities. Students also have to organize events themselves across separate platforms, creating extra friction when managing schedules and commitments.

User Research

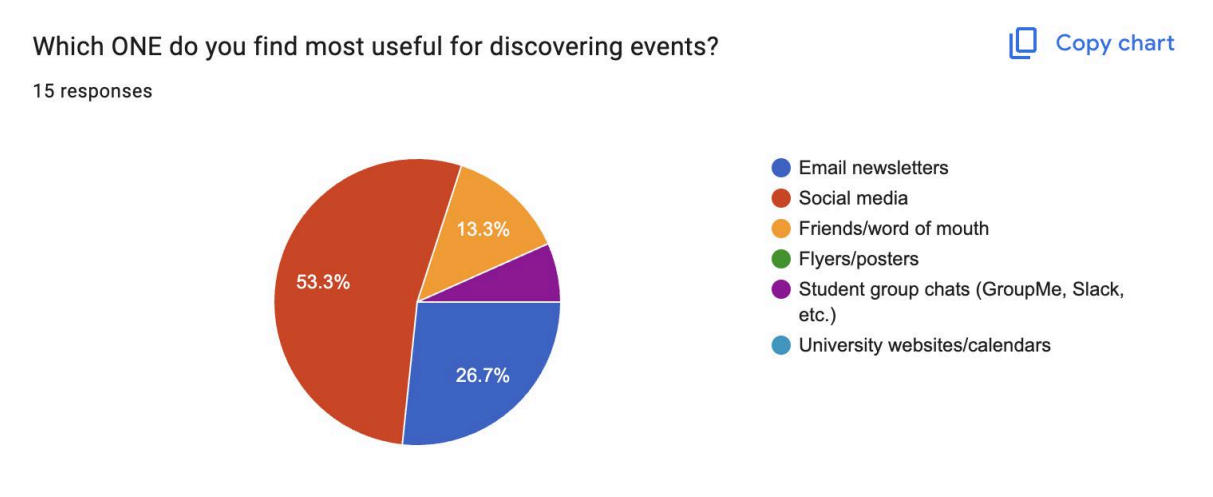
Survey

To better understand how Penn students currently discover and manage campus events, I conducted user research focused on event discovery habits, frustrations, and feature preferences. The survey questions were grouped into three main categories to identify both user pain points and opportunities for design improvement.

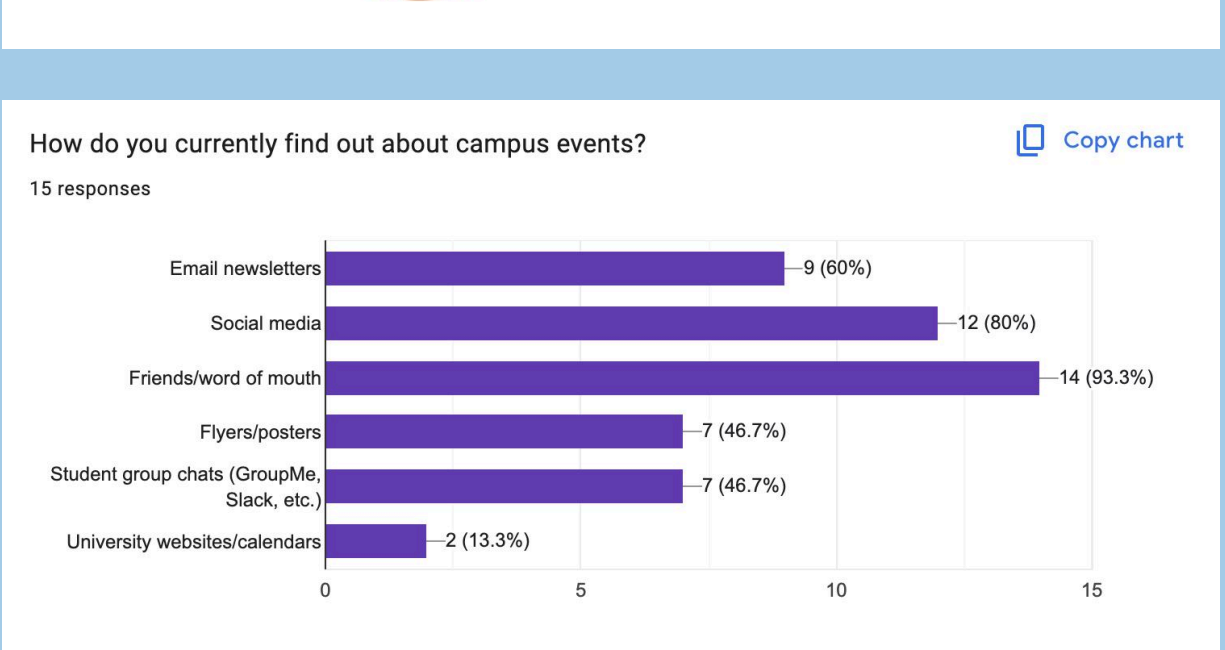
Current Event Discovery Behaviors


How involved are you in campus activities?

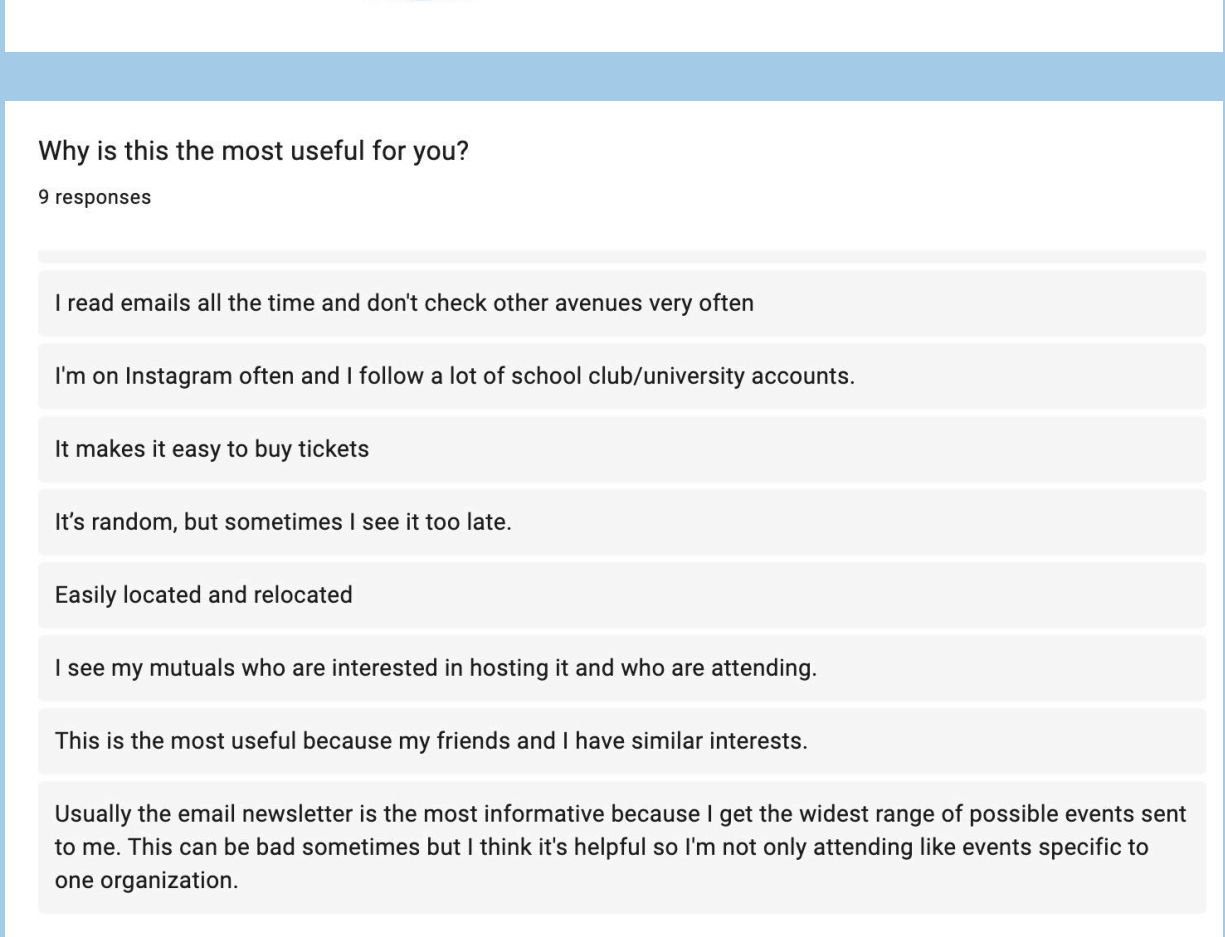
15 responses


Which ONE do you find most useful for discovering events?

15 responses


How do you currently find out about campus events?

15 responses


Why is this the most useful for you?

9 responses

I read emails all the time and don't check other avenues very often

I'm on Instagram often and I follow a lot of school club/university accounts.

It makes it easy to buy tickets

It's random, but sometimes I see it too late.

Easily located and relocated

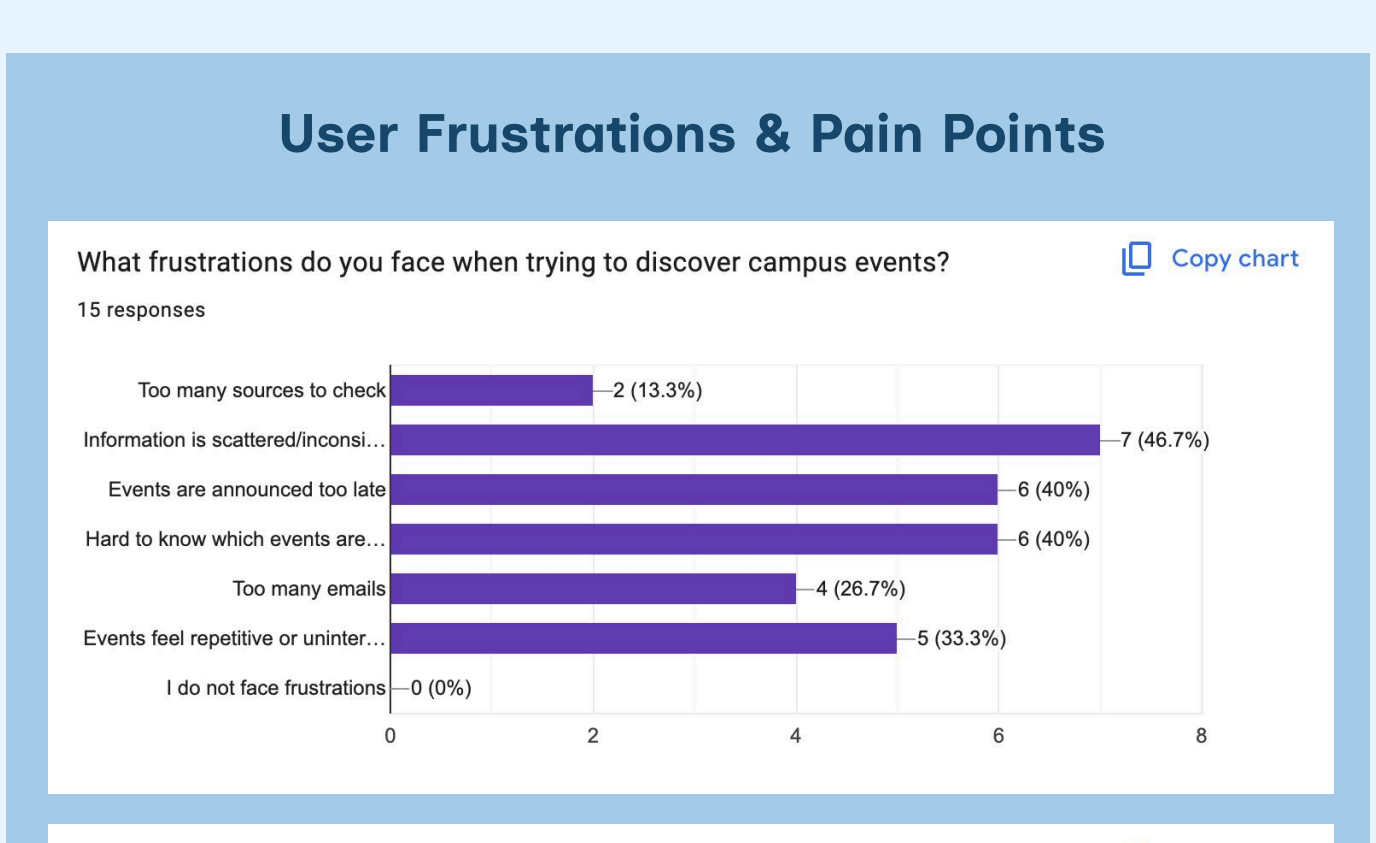
I see my mutuals who are interested in hosting it and who are attending.

This is the most useful because my friends and I have similar interests.

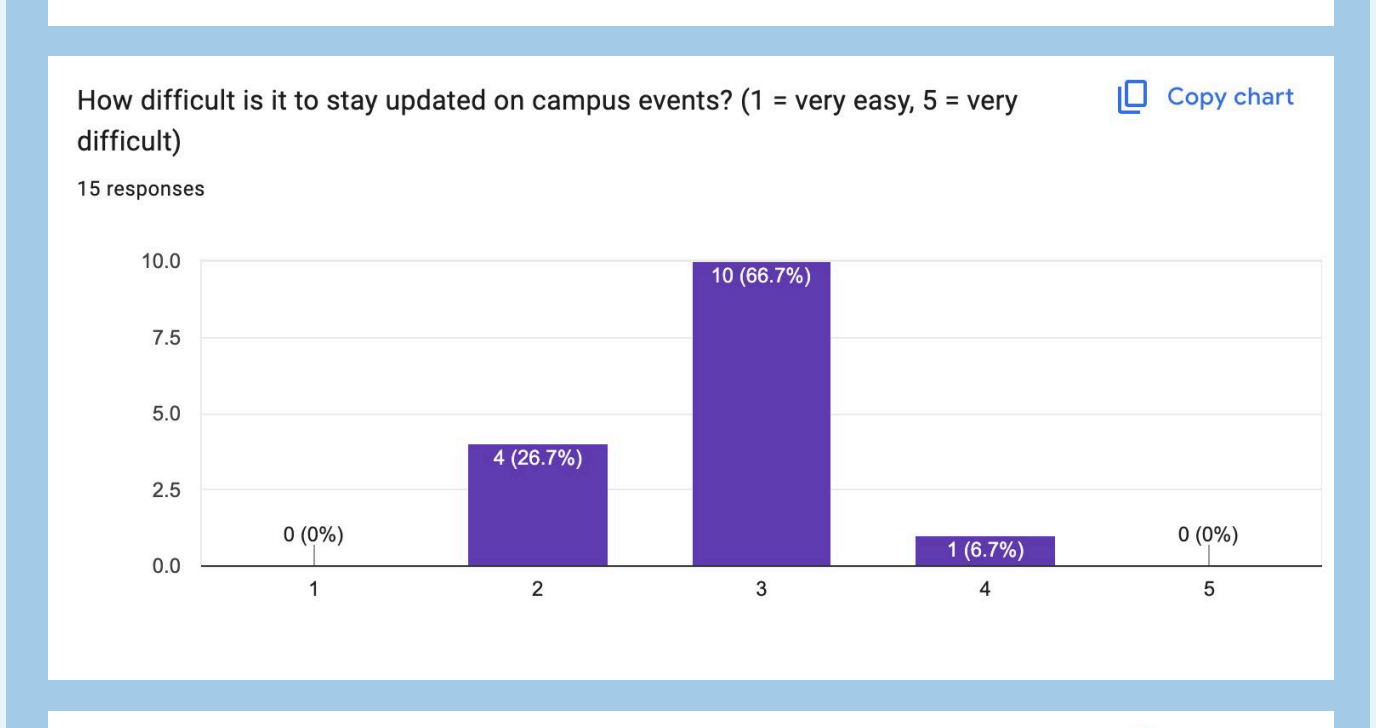
Usually the email newsletter is the most informative because I get the widest range of possible events sent to me. This can be bad sometimes but I think it's helpful so I'm not only attending like events specific to one organization.

- Most students are already actively engaged in campus activities.
- Students rely heavily on informal and fragmented discovery methods.
- Social influence strongly impacts event participation.
- Students value convenience and accessibility over platform type.
- Event discovery is inconsistent and easy to miss.

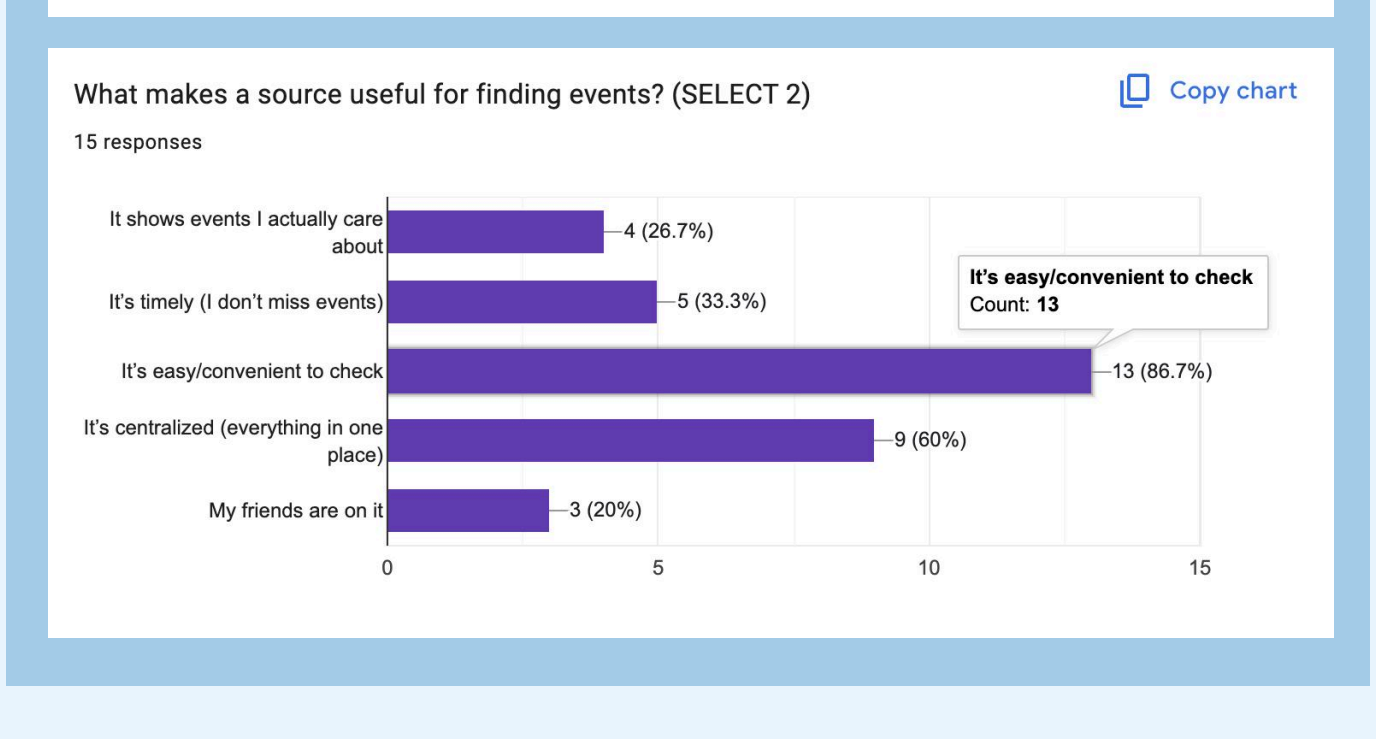
User Frustrations & Pain Points


What frustrations do you face when trying to discover campus events?

15 responses

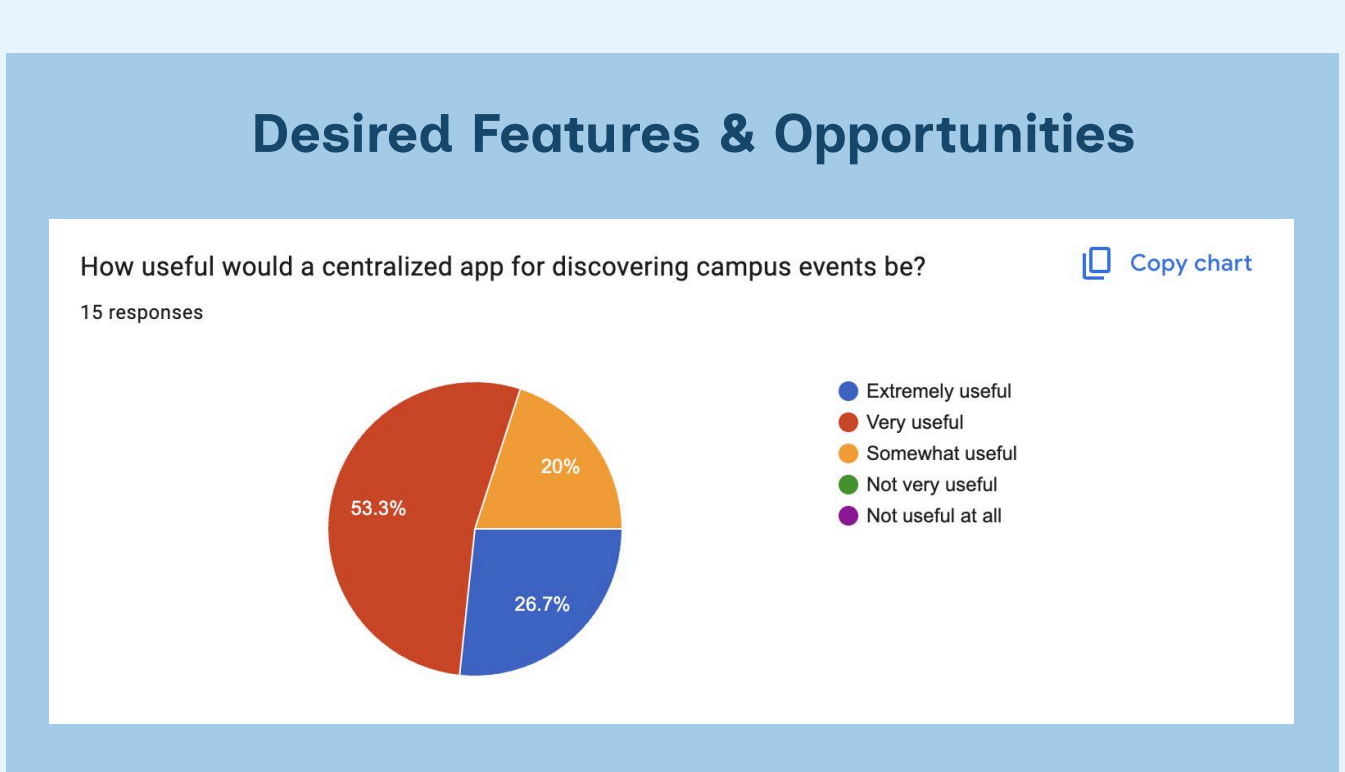

How difficult is it to stay updated on campus events? (1 = very easy, 5 = very difficult)

15 responses

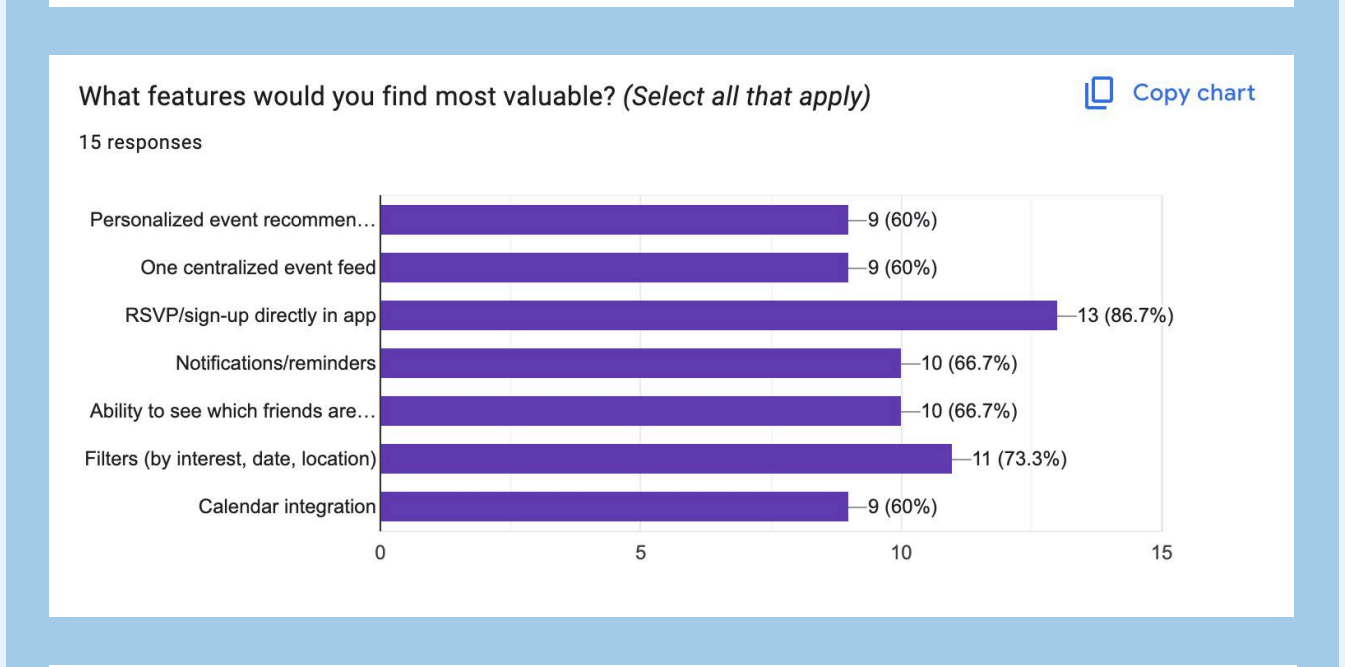

What makes a source useful for finding events? (SELECT 2)

15 responses

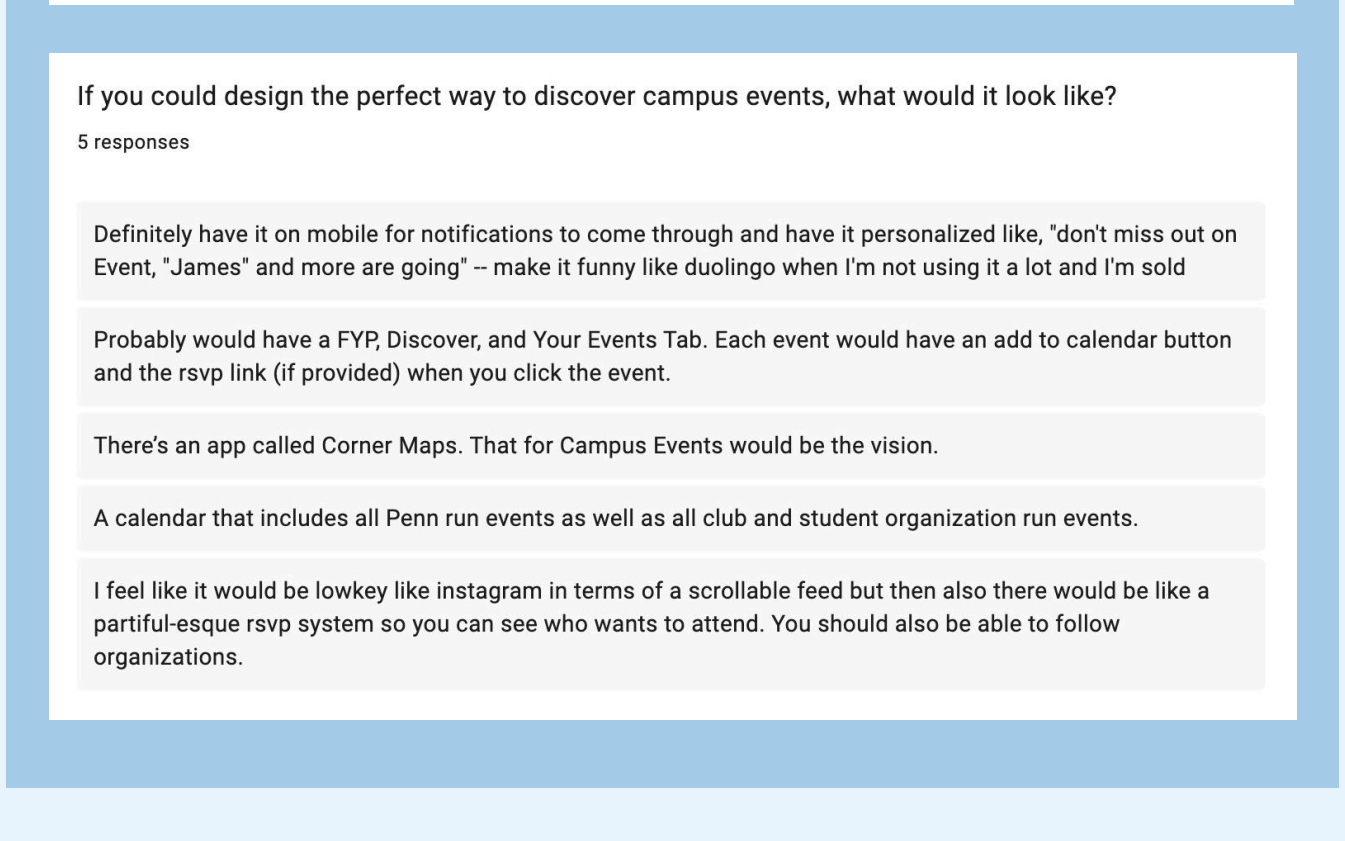
Desired Features & Opportunities


How useful would a centralized app for discovering campus events be?

15 responses


What features would you find most valuable? *(Select all that apply)*

15 responses


If you could design the perfect way to discover campus events, what would it look like?

5 responses

Definitely have it on mobile for notifications to come through and have it personalized like, "don't miss out on Event, "James" and more are going" -- make it funny like duolingo when I'm not using it a lot and I'm sold

Probably would have a FYP, Discover, and Your Events Tab. Each event would have an add to calendar button and the rsvp link (if provided) when you click the event.

There's an app called Corner Maps. That for Campus Events would be the vision.

A calendar that includes all Penn run events as well as all club and student organization run events.

I feel like it would be lowkey like instagram in terms of a scrollable feed but then also there would be like a partiful-esque rsvp system so you can see who wants to attend. You should also be able to follow organizations.

User Interviews

I conducted 3 user interviews to get more information on how students discover events at Penn and any frustration points they face. Most students relied on fragmented platforms such as Instagram, emails, group chats, and word of mouth, making event discovery overwhelming and difficult to track. These interviews revealed key pain points around organization, reminders, and social discovery, which directly informed the design decisions behind PennEvents.

Insights I gained:

- Students rely on multiple fragmented platforms to discover campus events.
- Event information is often inconsistent, scattered, or announced too late.
- Students struggle to keep track of events after initially discovering them.
- Social visibility plays a major role in event interest and participation.
- Students value centralized organization, reminders, and easy calendar integration.

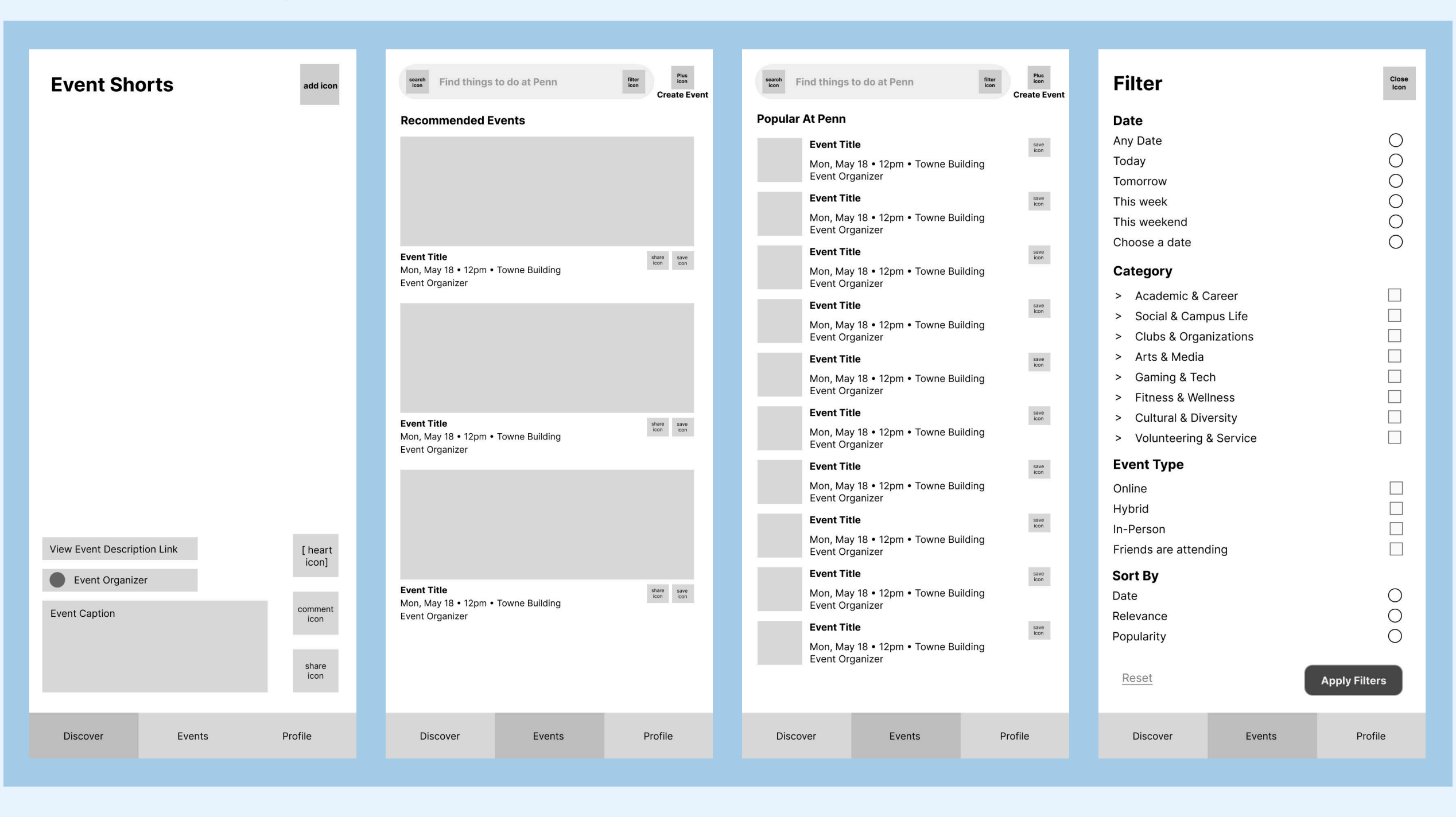
> Students want a centralized event discovery platform that makes it easy to find, save, organize, and keep track of campus events without relying on multiple disconnected sources.

Wireframe

In my wireframe prototype, I focused on creating a simple and streamlined event registration flow that allowed users to discover, filter, and sign up for campus events with minimal friction. I explored multiple methods of event discovery, including browsing through a dedicated short-form event reels tab and searching through a dedicated events tab with filtering functionality.

I also focused on exploring how to make event discovery feel more engaging and interactive for students. I explored this in a Reels-style event page and indicators showing how many friends attend. Because I had more emphasis on discovery, I designed the app around three primary tabs: Discover, Events, and Profile.

Flow 1: Discovering Events


Event Shorts
add icon
View Event Description Link
Event Organizer
Event Caption
[heart icon]
comment icon
share icon
Find things to do at Penn
Create Event
Recommended Events
Event Title
Mon, May 18 • 12pm • Towne Building
Event Organizer
Popular At Penn
Filter
Close icon
Date
Any Date
Today
Tomorrow
This week
This weekend
Choose a date
Category
Academic & Career
Social & Campus Life
Clubs & Organizations
Arts & Media
Gaming & Tech
Fitness & Wellness
Cultural & Diversity
Volunteering & Service
Event Type
Online
Hybrid
In-Person
Friends are attending
Sort By
Date
Relevance
Popularity
Reset
Apply Filters
Discover
Events
Profile

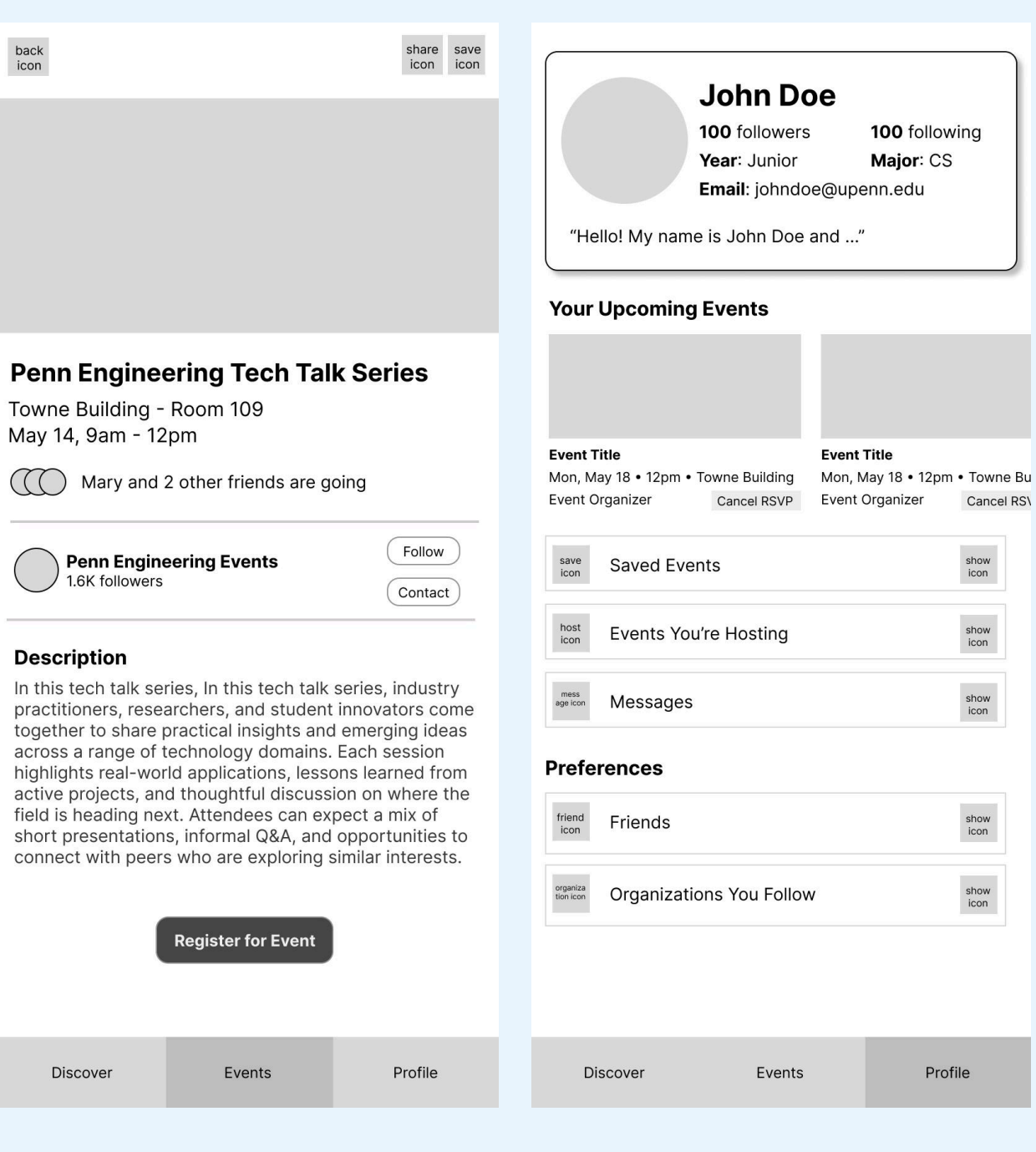
In this version, I designed the Discover page, which featured short-form event content, to serve as the homepage experience. My goal was to create an engaging and immediate way for students to begin exploring campus events as soon as they opened the app. I also designed a typical events tab, which is how you would normally discover events, which is through searching and filtering for events, or scrolling through the recommended and popular events. I wanted students to use an app that felt familiar to them.

Flow 2: Event RSVP

RSVP includes viewing the description page of the event and registering for the event through the button. My idea was to have all the important details about the event in the event description page, so that students have everything they need in one place. This means being able to see who else is attending

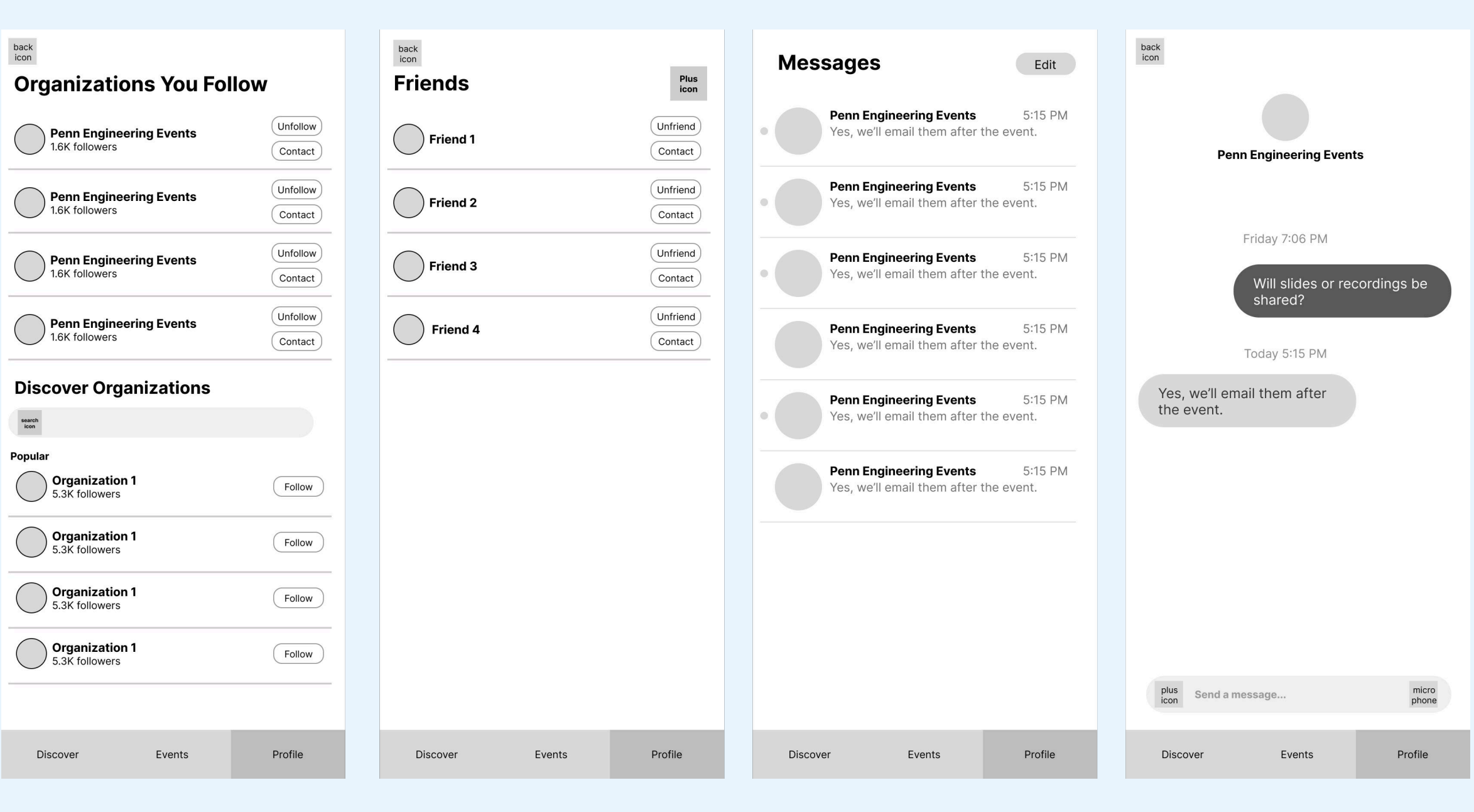
I also added the functionality to follow or contact an organization, which provides an easy way for students to communicate with organizations.

When students sign up for an event, that event will be added to their upcoming events section in the profile page.


back icon
share icon
save icon
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
Towne Building - Room 109
May 14, 9am - 12pm
Mary and 2 other friends are going
Penn Engineering Events
1.6K followers
Follow
Contact
Description
Register for Event
John Doe
100 followers
100 following
Year: Junior
Major: CS
Email: johndoe@upenn.edu
"Hello! My name is John Doe and …"
Your Upcoming Events
Event Title
Mon, May 18 • 12pm • Towne Building
Event Organizer
Cancel RSVP
Saved Events
Events You're Hosting
Messages
Preferences
Friends
Organizations You Follow
Discover
Events
Profile

In this tech talk series, In this tech talk series, industry practitioners, researchers, and student innovators come together to share practical insights and emerging ideas across a range of technology domains. Each session highlights real-world applications, lessons learned from active projects, and thoughtful discussion on where the field is heading next. Attendees can expect a mix of short presentations, informal Q&A, and opportunities to connect with peers who are exploring similar interests.

Flow 3: Social Engagement


back icon
Organizations You Follow
Penn Engineering Events
1.6K followers
Unfollow
Contact
Discover Organizations
Popular
Organization 1
5.3K followers
Follow
Friends
Friend 1
Friend 2
Friend 3
Friend 4
Unfriend
Contact
Messages
Edit
Penn Engineering Events
5:15 PM
Friday 7:06 PM
Today 5:15 PM
Send a message…
Discover
Events
Profile

Yes, we'll email them after the event.

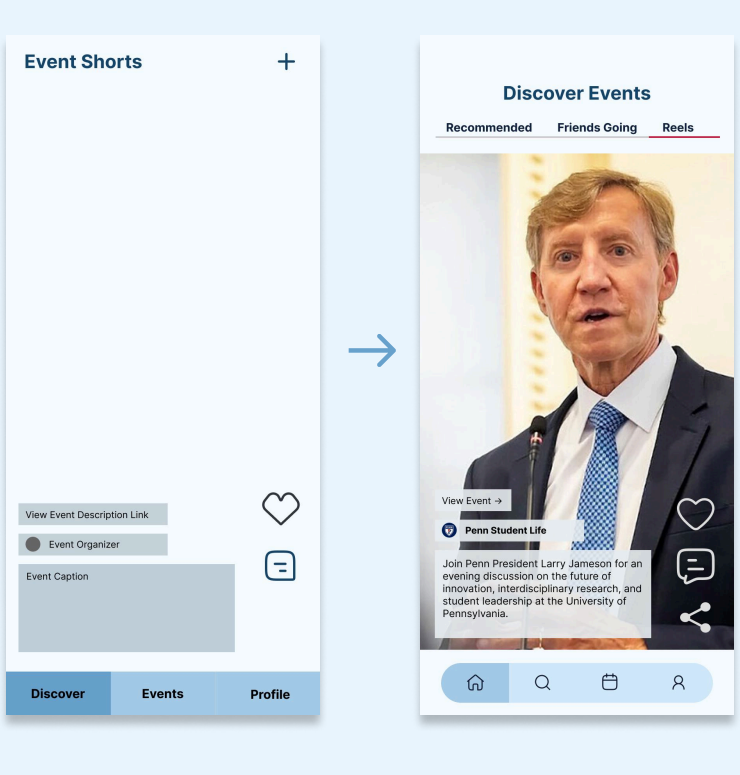
Will slides or recordings be shared?

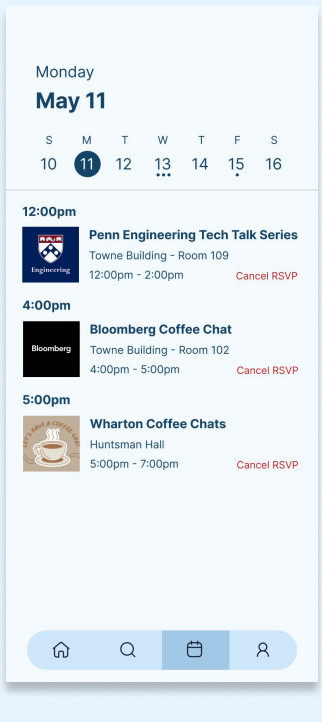
Students wanted a centralized platform where they could not only discover events, but also manage and interact with everything related to campus events in one place. Because of this, I designed the profile page to act as a central management hub where users can access followed organizations, friends, messages, saved events, and hosted events without needing to switch between multiple platforms.

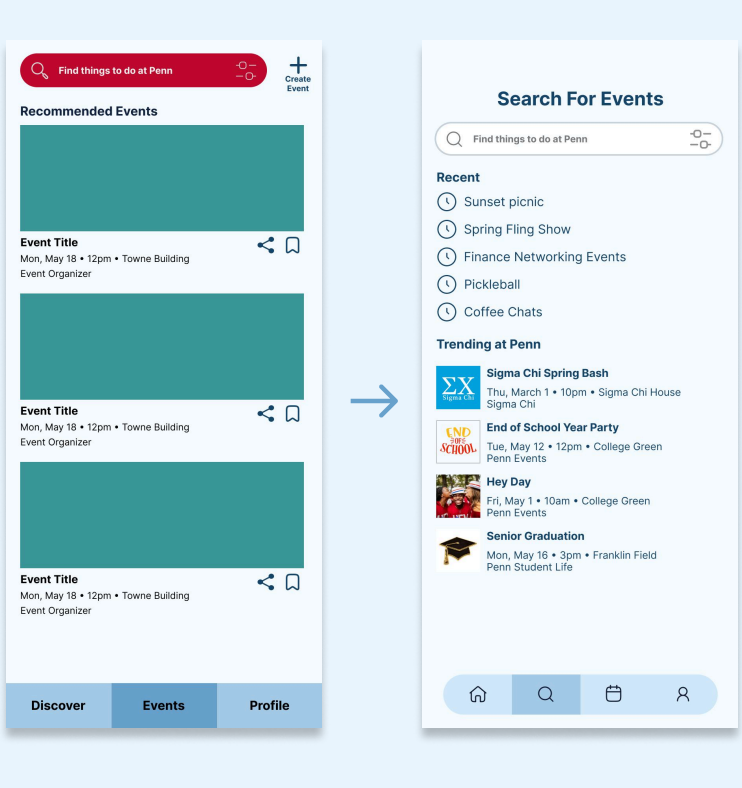
Feedback

To gather feedback on my design, I conducted user interviews to evaluate whether the app felt intuitive and easy to navigate. The interviews focused on how effectively students could discover, filter, and register for campus events, as well as the clarity of event information and the usefulness of personalized recommendations.

Feedback	Design Changes
Users responded positively to the original shorts-based "For You" page, finding it an engaging and enjoyable way to discover events. However, several users were unclear about how personalization worked beyond the shorts feed.	I redesigned the experience into a more dedicated "For You" page featuring separate tabs for Reels, Recommended Events, and Events Friends Are Attending to better communicate where recommendations come from.
Users wanted stronger event management tools, including calendar integration, clearer post-registration flows, reminders/notifications, and better visibility into registered and past events.	Designed a calendar view to allow for students to easily keep track of their RSVP events and created functionality to view past events and modify notification preferences.
Some elements like the overly bright search button, vibrant tag colors, red comment section felt inconsistent or distracting and could be fixed to be more readable.	I refined the visual hierarchy by reducing overly saturated colors, improving contrast and readability, and creating a more consistent color system across buttons, tags, and interactive elements.


Event Shorts
Discover Events
Recommended
Friends Going
Reels


Monday
May 11

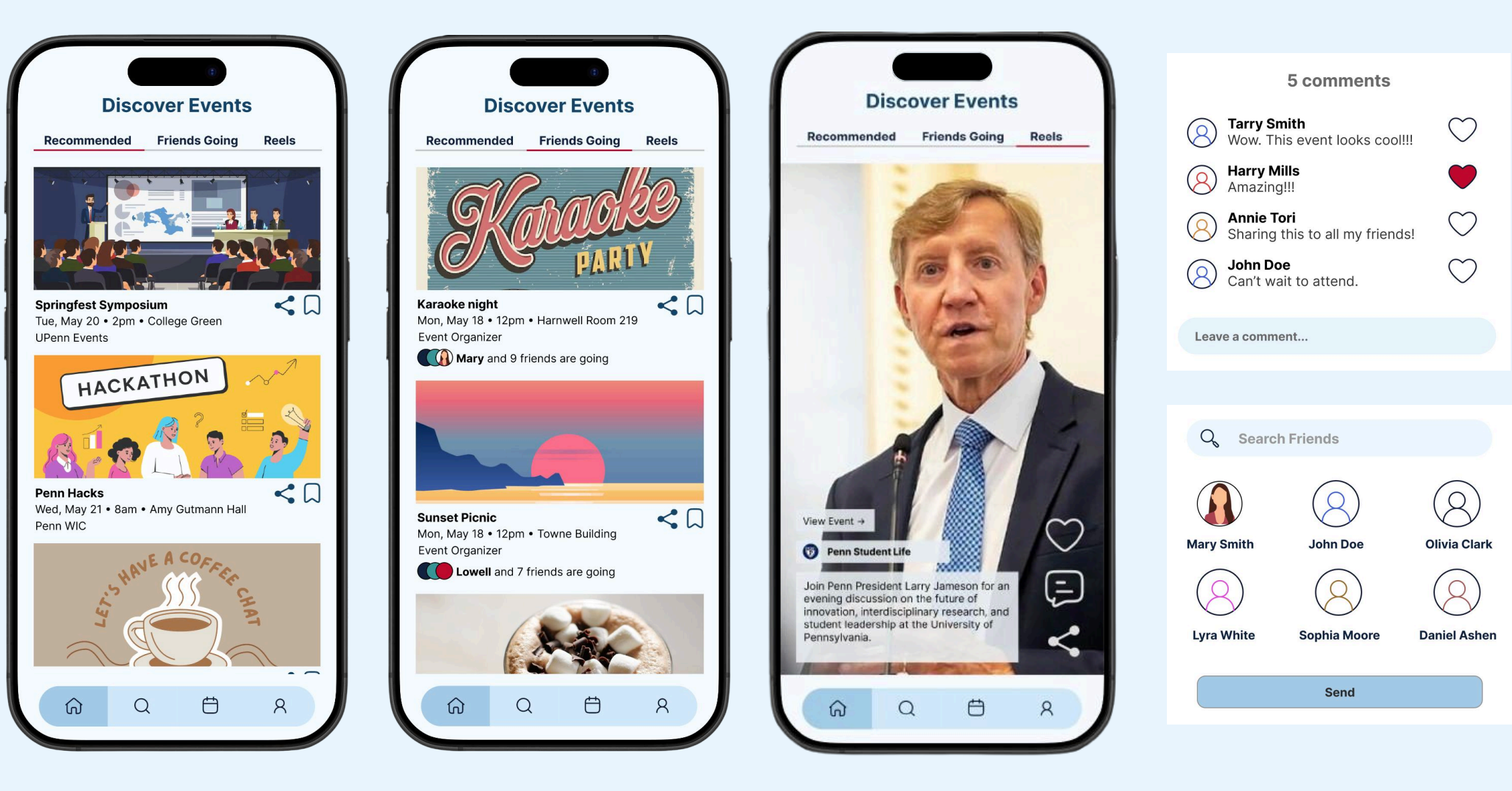

Recommended Events
Search For Events

Solution

Flow 1: Searching for an Event

The app begins with a personalized FYP, where users can browse recommended events based on their interests, search history, and previously attended events. This helps students discover events more easily across disconnected platforms.

The FYP includes three tabs: **Recommended**, **Friends Going**, and **Reels**. The Friends Going tab encourages social participation by showing events friends are attending. The Reels tab makes event discovery more engaging and familiar to students.


Discover Events
Recommended
Friends Going
Reels
Springfest Symposium
Tue, May 20 • 2pm • College Green
UPenn Events
HACKATHON
Penn Hacks
Wed, May 21 • 8am • Amy Gutmann Hall
Penn WIC
LET'S HAVE A COFFEE CHAT
Karaoke PARTY
Karaoke night
Mon, May 18 • 12pm • Harnwell Room 219
Event Organizer
Mary and 9 friends are going
Sunset Picnic
Mon, May 18 • 12pm • Towne Building
Event Organizer
Lowell and 7 friends are going
View Event
Penn Student Life
5 comments
Leave a comment…
Search Friends
Mary Smith
John Doe
Olivia Clark
Lyra White
Sophia Moore
Daniel Ashen
Send

Join Penn President Larry Jameson for an evening discussion on the future of innovation, interdisciplinary research, and student leadership at the University of Pennsylvania.

Tarry Smith: Wow. This event looks cool!!!

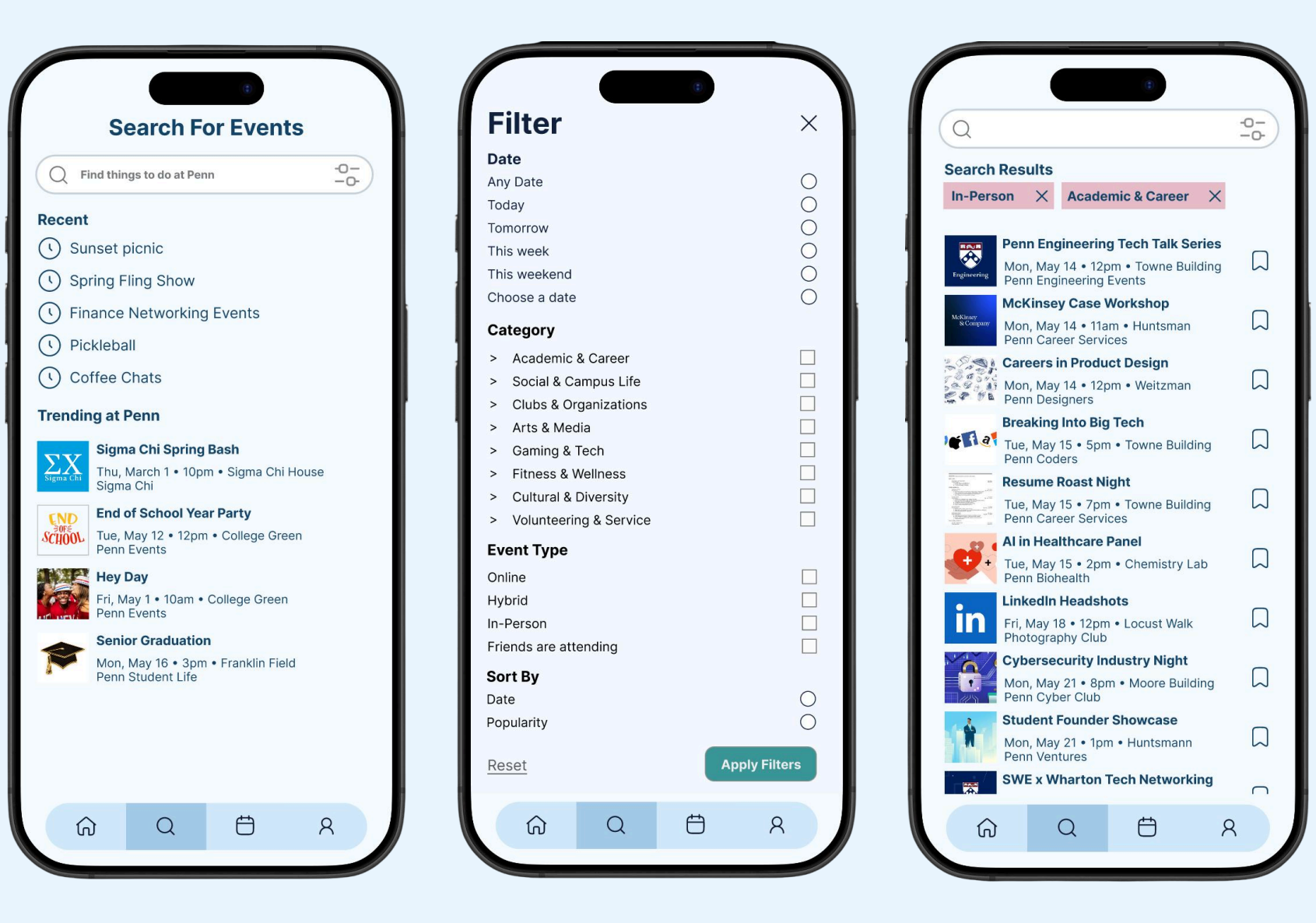
Harry Mills: Amazing!!!

Annie Tori: Sharing this to all my friends!

John Doe: Can't wait to attend.

Users can also search for events directly and apply filters to quickly find relevant events.

While searching for events, the app keeps track of recently searched for events and events that are trending. I did this to demonstrate recognition over recall and efficiency of use UI/UX principle.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Find things to do at Penn
Recent
Sunset picnic
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Pickleball
Coffee Chats
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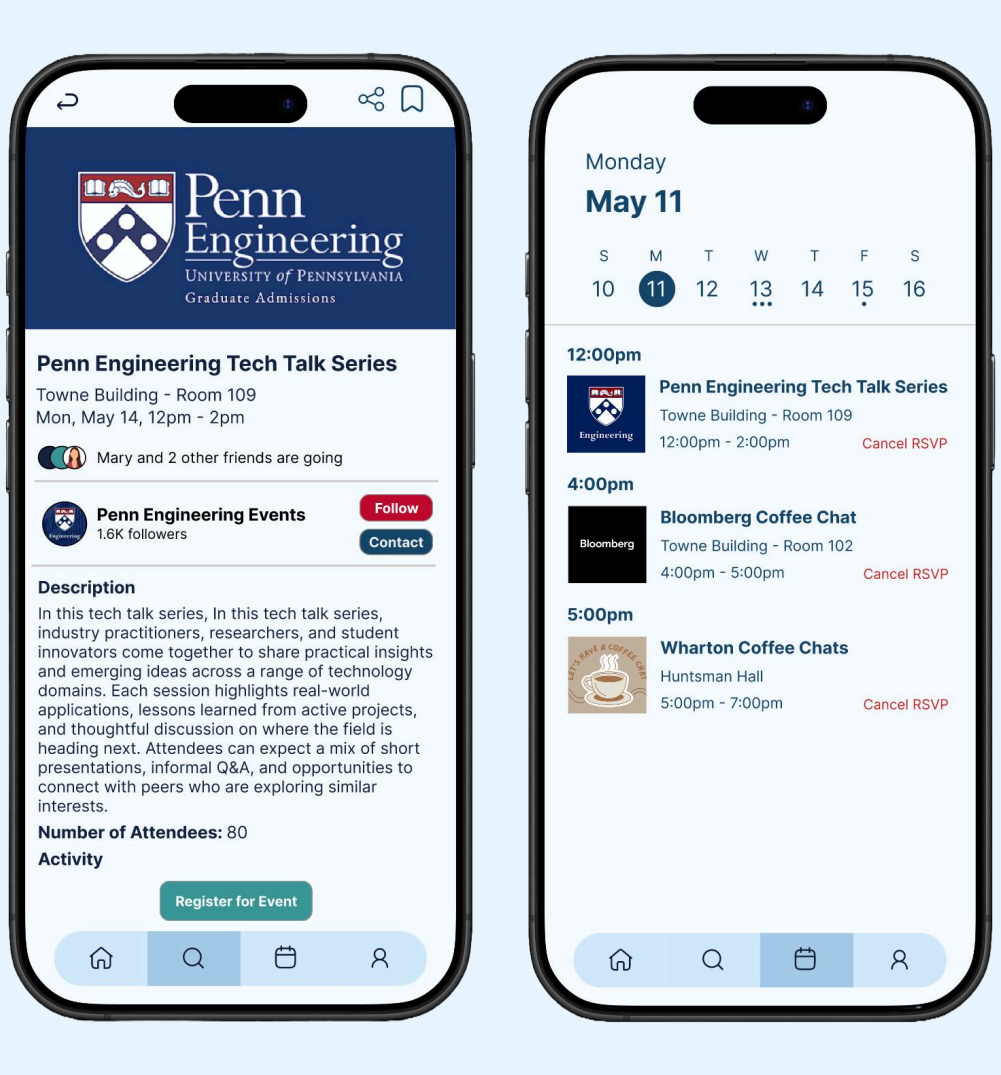
Thu, March 1 • 10pm • Sigma Chi House
End of School Year Party
Tue, May 12 • 12pm • College Green
Hey Day
Fri, May 1 • 10am • College Green
Senior Graduation
Mon, May 16 • 3pm • Franklin Field
Filter
Date
Category
Event Type
Sort By
Reset
Apply Filters
Search Results
In-Person
Academic & Career
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
McKinsey Case Workshop
Careers in Product Design
Breaking Into Big Tech
Resume Roast Night
AI in Healthcare Panel
LinkedIn Headshots
Cybersecurity Industry Night
Student Founder Showcase
SWE x Wharton Tech Networking

Flow 2: Registering for an Event

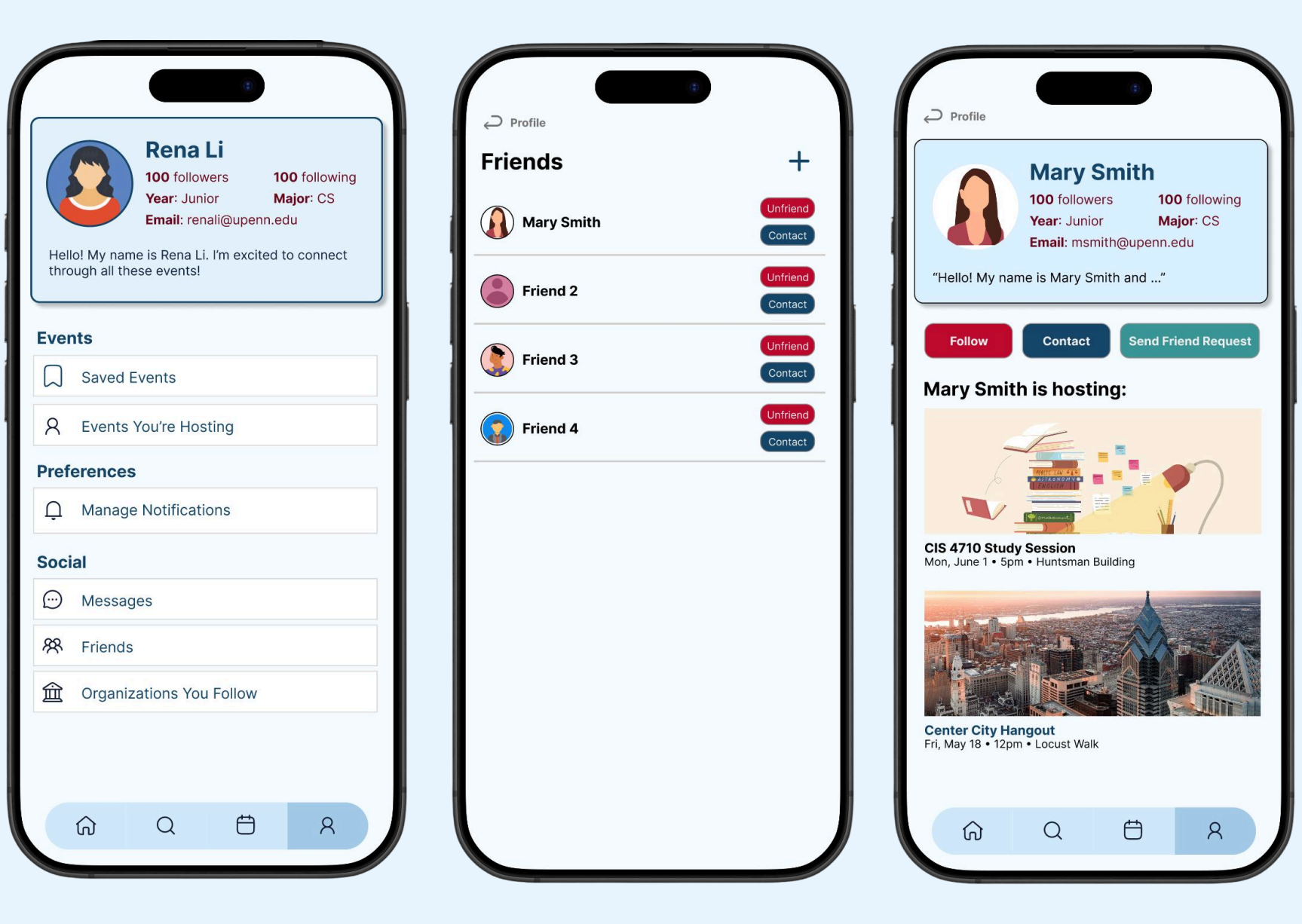
After selecting an event, users can view descriptions, updates, and registration details in one streamlined flow. Registered events are automatically added to the calendar page, helping users keep track of upcoming events.


Penn Engineering
University of Pennsylvania
Graduate Admissions
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
Towne Building - Room 109
Mon, May 14, 12pm - 2pm
Mary and 2 other friends are going
Penn Engineering Events
1.6K followers
Follow
Contact
Description
Number of Attendees: 80
Activity
Register for Event
Monday
May 11
12:00pm
Penn Engineering Tech Talk Series
4:00pm
Bloomberg Coffee Chat
5:00pm
Wharton Coffee Chats
Cancel RSVP

Flow 3: Social Discovery & Message Flow

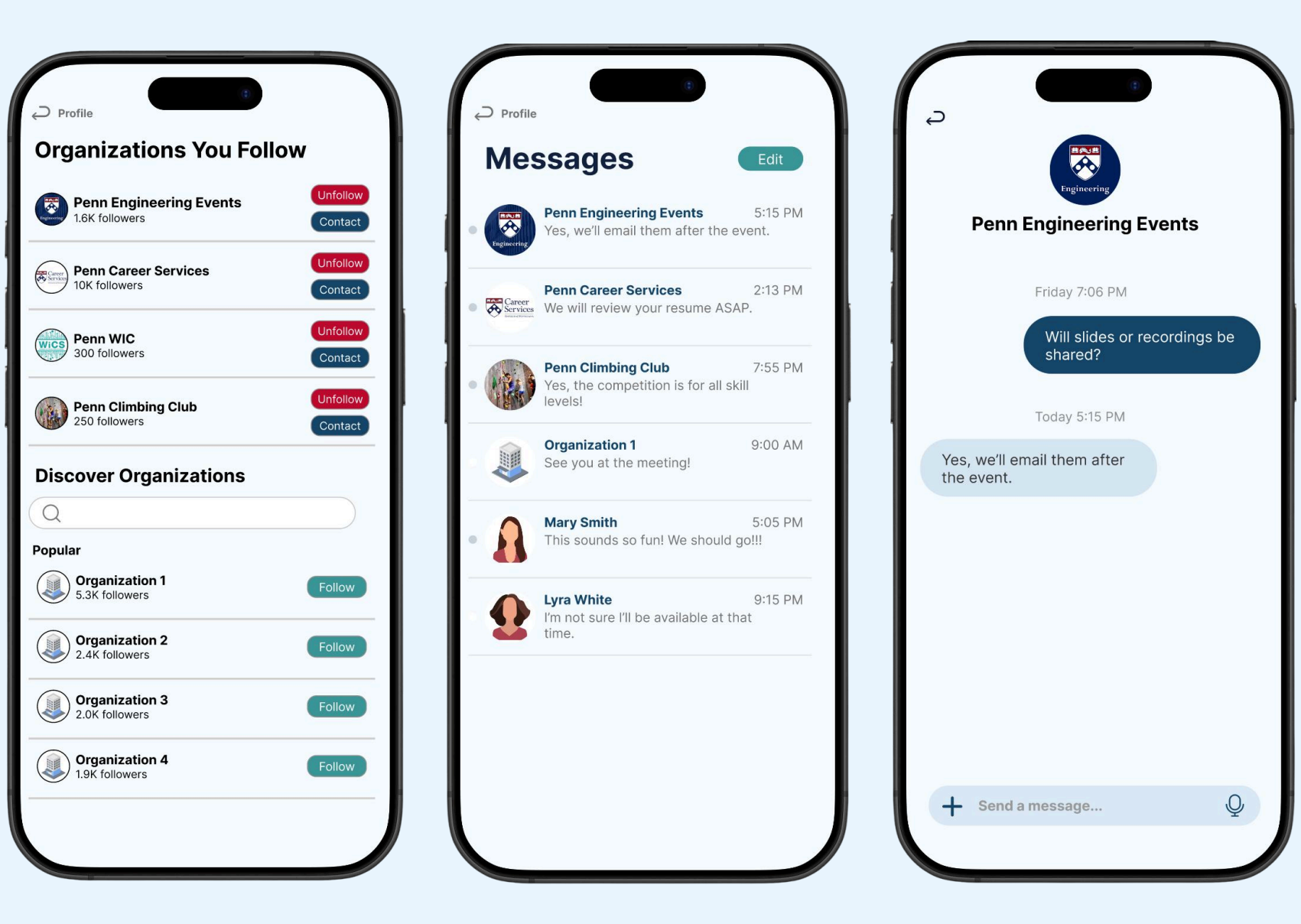
This flow focuses on the social and communication aspects of the app.

Users can view their friends list, explore friend profiles, see events their friends are hosting or attending, and directly message them through the platform.


Rena Li
100 followers
100 following
Year: Junior
Major: CS
Email: renali@upenn.edu
Events
Saved Events
Events You're Hosting
Preferences
Manage Notifications
Social
Messages
Friends
Organizations You Follow
Profile
Friends
Mary Smith
Friend 2
Friend 3
Friend 4
Unfriend
Contact
Mary Smith
Year: Junior
Major: CS
Email: msmith@upenn.edu
Follow
Contact
Send Friend Request
Mary Smith is hosting:
CIS 4710 Study Session
Mon, June 1 • 5pm • Huntsman Building
Center City Hangout
Fri, May 18 • 12pm • Locust Walk

Hello! My name is Rena Li. I'm excited to connect through all these events!

"Hello! My name is Mary Smith and …"


Profile
Organizations You Follow
Penn Engineering Events
Penn Career Services
Penn WiC
Penn Climbing Club
Unfollow
Contact
Discover Organizations
Popular
Organization 1
Organization 2
Organization 3
Organization 4
Follow
Messages
Edit
Penn Engineering Events
Friday 7:06 PM
Today 5:15 PM
Send a message…

Penn Engineering Events: Yes, we'll email them after the event.

Penn Career Services: We will review your resume ASAP.

Penn Climbing Club: Yes, the competition is for all skill levels!

Organization 1: See you at the meeting!

Mary Smith: This sounds so fun! We should go!!!

Lyra White: I'm not sure I'll be available at that time.

Will slides or recordings be shared?

Yes, we'll email them after the event.

The flow also allows users to follow organizations, browse organization profiles, and contact them directly within the app to ask questions or receive updates about events.

By integrating messaging and social discovery into the experience, the app creates a more connected and interactive way for students to engage with campus events and communities.

Reflection

With more development time, I would further expand the social and organizational aspects of the app, particularly features such as shared calendars with friends and more developed tools for hosts and organizations, since the current design primarily focuses on the student event discovery experience. I would also like to introduce richer app interactions through animations, interactive event previews, and more dynamic UI elements. Additional features such as event analytics for hosts and students, engagement insights, and campus-wide leaderboards could further increase interaction and participation within the platform.

Through this project, I learned about the importance of balancing functionality and simplicity when designing mobile applications. I've never done UI/UX design on mobile sized frames, and while there are a lot of information that could be included, I got to learn and practice how to simplify and condense information onto a smaller frame. All in all, the process taught me how to prioritize the core user journey and reduce unnecessary complexity within the interface.

Additionally, I gained experience designing complete app systems rather than just individual screens. Creating flows for event discovery, registration, messaging, notifications, and scheduling helped me better understand how different features connect together to create a smoother and more cohesive user experience.

Finally, this project strengthened my skills in prototyping within Figma, designing mobile-first interfaces, and creating more cohesive and user-centered experiences through iterative UI/UX design.